and conditioning coach, lays out treasure hunts for us around Brisbane. We are sent off individually on these hunts to find monuments. Even before the first ball, we are weathered and beaten, putting on brave faces as best we can, as the encircling media from home and Australia stretch themselves to judge us. Rory Burns is bowled first ball, one around his legs. It's a dismissal that is months in the making – a fate already decided by the preparation, and one that will play out across an entire, miserable tour around Australia.

The daily Covid tests are so brutal that you feel like they are almost intentionally trying to reach your brain through your nose. On Christmas Day, we are sent to the beach and they give us hot dogs on white bread. It's starting to feel like such a prisoner captive situation that you daren't even ask for ketchup. If any players get Covid, there are full hazmat suits for anyone who has been around them. By the end of the tour, the word survival is being used regularly but never in a cricket sense. Everyone is desperate to go home, and it shows.

The madness begins to extend into a paranoia and slightly edgy thinking between all of us. I really like Chris Silverwood but the alien intensity of the situation has understandably taken its toll. Rory Burns is dropped at Melbourne and he finds out through the media. Burns is upset that he hasn't heard from anyone inside the camp. Silverwood is livid about the leak and hears that it has come through Broady's ghost writer for his column. Silverwood pulls Broady in, volleying him with a tirade about the leak. Broad doesn't know anything about the leak and pleads his innocence. A few days later, it turns out that the leak has come from Silverwood himself, mentioning the team in earshot of the press. He is his own leak. It is that sort of tour. At the start of the same Test, Silverwood and Root have spent half an hour at the pitch on the morning, analysing it. Shane Warne, on television duties, walked past and, taking one glance at it, said, 'What are you looking for, boys? It's clearly a bowl first.' Our heads were all scrambled. It was no one's fault. We had done pretty well just to stay on the tour at all. All the results feel foregone conclusions, and no cricket is even going to be really remembered by anyone who played it. When I get home, everything feels different, like I'm locked out of my own life and in a space where it will take time to remember what the reason for playing cricket really is.